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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

The rooks were louder than the fiddle. Alexander heard them before he reached the top of the hill road, quarrelling in the chestnuts above the gate, and under them, thinner, the fiddle still hunting for its pitch, sawing the same three notes up and down as if it meant to argue them into agreement.

He had been out since seven, sent by his father to look at the second cut on Harrow's Fen, and he had looked at it: a long wet meadow under haze, the ricks standing in it like loaves set out to cool, a sluice gate that wanted seeing to. Now the castle stood before him on its plateau with the morning full on it, and he looked at that too, the way he had been taught to look at any house, his own included, from the oldest part outward. The great square keep first, plainest of all, built by men who had not expected to be visited. Then the chapel spire, and the long eastern range running away along the edge of the plateau with its leaded windows full of light. Below the walls the forest fell steeply away, untouched in living memory. The stone had weathered to the colour of an old hayrick. Someone had tied harvest ribbons, red and yellow, to the iron rings along the gate wall, and they lifted in the small wind as though the wall had agreed to be festive for one week of the year and no longer.

He gave his horse to a stable boy at the gate, and his coat with it.

The cider cart had gone in to the axle just inside, where the ground was always soft and where, every year, somebody forgot that it was. Mr. Fenwick stood beside it with his hat crushed in one fist, a short square man whose voice had been made for calling cattle across three fields.

"Hold hard, bor. Hold *hard*. That's a full load, and if she goes over I'll have every drop out of somebody's hide."

Four estate hands were already leaning on the back of it. The youngest was Carrow, wiry and quick, the Widow Carrow's son, who rode the house's errands faster than anyone in the stables. Alexander did not stop to consider it. He set his shoulder to the tailboard beside them, found the place where the wood was wettest and the grip worst because the good places were taken, and pushed when they pushed. Over his bent back two of the men exchanged a look. He caught it at the edge of his sight and chose not to.

The wheel came up out of the mud with a sound like a boot leaving a bog. The cart rocked, settled, and rolled on toward the trestles with every barrel aboard, and Mr. Fenwick put his hat back on in order to take it off again.

"Much obliged, Master Alexander. Much obliged, sir."

"Not at all, Mr. Fenwick."

He was the tallest of them by half a head, and the only one whose hands were soft. There was a splinter in the heel of his right hand and a bloom of cider across his charcoal waistcoat, and he had tied his cravat a good deal looser that morning than fashion asked, as he did most mornings now. Nobody had said a word about the cravat yet. That was the whole value of a rebellion small enough to deny. He worked the splinter out with his thumbnail while the hands went back to their barrels. They liked him; he knew it. They would sooner have sat down in his father's chair than called him by his Christian name.

"You've his eyes, Master Alexander." The Widow Carrow had come up beside him, small and upright in her Sunday black, to see that her son was in one piece. She nodded across the yard toward the judging table. "Always looking for what's wrong with a thing."

He thanked her, and did not believe her. His eyes were brown, like his father's; everyone said so. But his father looked at a thing and saw what was wrong with it and then, unhurried, saw what to do about it, and Alexander had only ever managed the first half.

His father stood at the judging table in his shirtsleeves, with four marrows of heroic size laid out before him and Farmer Hodge on the far side of them.

"Weight, Your Grace," Hodge said. He was a tall, stooped man who argued with his whole neck. "Always has been weight."

Edward Sterling, seventeenth Duke of Norwich, considered the marrows. He was a solid man rather than an elegant one, built by years of work out of doors, and he stood as though he expected weather. His left hand was in his pocket, turning something over, as it always did when he listened. "It has always been weight, Mr. Hodge, because you have always grown the heaviest. That is a tradition. It is not an argument."

"Girth's naught but show. Any fool can blow a marrow up with water." Hodge did not look at the Widow Carrow's entry, second from the left, with such force that everyone else did.

His father turned his head to look at it too, and the sun found the old pale scars at his temple and along one cheekbone, scars that had been there as long as Alexander could remember and that nobody had ever explained. He drew out his watch, glanced at it, and put it away again, as if the marrow had been allotted a fixed time and was using it. Then he gave the question exactly the pause, grave and unhurried, that Alexander had seen him give to letters arriving under seal from London.

"Then we have two questions before this table, not one. Whether the marrow is large, and whether it is honest."

A ripple ran round the people nearest the table, something short of laughter, the sound tenants made when the Duke said a thing they would repeat at their own fires that night. Alexander, who had stood at the head of a good many tenants' dinners, had never once been given it.

His father looked up then and found him across the yard, and gave him a short nod, the nod for a duty seen to.

His mother had placed herself at the end of the preserves table, near enough to hear every word of the marrow dispute and a careful yard too far to be appealed to by either side. Amelia Sterling wore the festival the way she wore everything, as though it had been arranged for her convenience and she was too gracious to say so. Her dark auburn hair was dressed close beneath a straw bonnet. Her green eyes were on her husband, fond and unhurried, the look of a woman at a play she had seen before and still enjoyed. As Alexander came up she peeled off one glove, finger by finger, to taste Mrs. Davies's damson cheese.

There had been a winter, the winter he was sixteen, when she had not taken her gloves off at all, not at table and not by the fire, and had told everyone it was the cold. He had teased her about it until she laughed. Now, when she lifted the bare hand to shade her eyes, the light caught the fine silver-grey lines across her palm, which he had long since stopped seeing.

"Should someone rescue him?" he asked.

"My darling, your father has never in his life needed rescuing from a marrow." She drew the glove back on. "Let him have his war. It's the only one I allow him."

"Is it Mr. Hodge's war, or the widow's?"

"It is the marrow's war. The rest of them are simply the ground it is fought over." She looked at his waistcoat. "And you have been pushing carts."

"One cart."

"One cart," she agreed, in a tone that closed the subject.

Thomas Barrow found him at the cider trestles. The under-steward was a big man in a coat too formal for the work he did in it, fair-haired and freckled to the knuckles from twenty summers out of doors, and he held his tally book the way other men held a prayer book. He touched his hat.

"Eight barrels in, sir, and two more coming from Thrower's once the cart's been seen to. You'll have been out to the Fen."

"I saw the ricks."

"My father brought the last load up himself last night. Knee and all." Thomas ran a thick finger down a column. "Most estates, a man goes lame, he goes without wage the same week. Not here." He made a mark, and tipped his head at the yard without looking up. "That's eleven families with hay to see their beasts through till spring, off that one meadow. Folk round here call it useless land, being wet half the year. His Grace won't sell it. Never would." He shut the book. "There's my two barrels now."

He went off toward the gate. Alexander stayed where he was.

Harrow's Fen had been a line in his father's ledgers for as long as he had been able to read them, a figure for rents and a figure for drainage and a note in the margin about the sluice. He had ridden the length of it that morning and seen ricks. Now he looked out past the wall toward the haze, and back at the yard, and found that he was counting. Mr. Fenwick, still shouting. The Davies boys fighting over whose turn it was on the swing hung from the lowest chestnut bough. The Widow Carrow, back beside her disgraced marrow, whose son had put his shoulder to the cart beside Alexander's own, and who kept one cow and would keep it through the winter because of a field he had looked at that morning and seen only hay in. He got as far as seven before he lost track of who belonged to which household, and he stood a moment longer in the smoke and the noise, trying to recover the other four.

The fiddle had found its note. Somebody began to clap along.

He went to find his sister.

The kitchen passage was cooler. He kept to the left-hand wall, as he always did, past the stillroom and the butler's pantry, whose door he did not look at, and came out into heat. Mrs. Thompson's kitchen on a festival morning ran on its own laws. She was a broad woman of fifty or so, floured to the elbow, her forearms red from the ovens, and she conducted four girls and a boy with a wooden spoon, and nobody answered back. Ribbons hung from the drying rack above the range. The girls went round Alexander as water goes round a post. Mrs. Thompson herself, passing with a sheet of pastry over one arm, reached up without breaking stride and plucked a straw out of his hair.

"Shows up something terrible on black, that does, love," she said, and was gone.

His sister was sitting in the middle of the great table, among the cooling racks, in a gown of figured blue silk that had no business within a mile of a kitchen. Its hem was muddied from the yard. A jam tart was balanced on her knee, and there was a crescent of flour on one cuff. Catherine was nineteen and had never in her life been still: one heel drummed against the table leg, and her fingers were breaking the edge off the tart in small pieces and not eating them. Her auburn hair had come down on one side into the waves it was always escaping into. The heat had put colour in her face, so that the little dark mark beside her left eye stood out like a full stop. Her eyes were their mother's, the same green, and quicker.

She saw him, and arranged herself. She straightened her back, folded her hands over the tart, and inclined her head with a precision none of her governesses had ever once managed to get out of her.

"Master Alexander," she said. "You look like a portrait of a duke that someone has left out in the rain. And you have brought the yard in on your waistcoat."

"And you have brought the drawing room into the kitchen," he said. "I believe Mrs. Thompson would rather have the yard."

"Off my table, love," Mrs. Thompson said, passing with a tray. "I've pastry wants that end."

Catherine laughed before she meant to and had to put a hand over her mouth. She moved six inches along the table, which seemed to satisfy honour on all sides. "Did you know," she said, "that in Saxony they make a crown out of the last sheaf of the harvest and carry it into the church with ribbons on it, and hang it up all winter until the mice have had half of it? I read it. A whole crown made out of—" Her eyes went past him to the window, and stayed there.

He waited. "Out of wheat," he offered.

"Hm? Oh. Yes." She looked back at him as though he had only that moment come in, and smiled, and put the tart into his hand. "Here. You've earned it, pushing carts."

He ate it standing up, as he had not eaten anything in a kitchen since he was ten years old. When he glanced at the window to see what she had been looking at, there was only the drying yard and the line of washing and, beyond the wall, the road going away between its hedges toward Norwich.

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By two o'clock the festival had become a sound beyond the wall: the fiddle, and a drum now with it, and somebody's dog, and under everything the long contented murmur of a yard full of people eating. The lower training yard held all of it at a distance, the way a quiet room holds a party two floors down.

Niall was there before him. He was always there before him. He stood at the narrow table against the north wall with his coat folded on the bench behind him and the wooden box open, laying the practice knives out in a line, and he did not look round when Alexander came through the gate in his shirtsleeves with his cravat already in his pocket.

"You're late," Niall said.

"I was pushing a cart."

"So the kitchen tells me." He set down the fourth knife, square to the third. "The kitchen says you pushed it very well."

Five knives went down on the table, one after another, dull iron with leather wound about the grips, in the same straight line they had gone down in for six years. There had been six, once. The sixth lay in the drawer of Alexander's dressing case upstairs, wrapped in a sheet of paper on which Niall had drawn in pencil the way a hand should close on a grip, and neither of them had ever said one word about where it had gone. Niall had never replaced it. Every lesson the box held five, and every lesson Alexander saw the gap.

Niall was three inches the taller and broader through the shoulder, built for use and not for show, and he stood the way he always stood, with his weight a little forward, as though he expected at any moment to have to move. The wind coming up off the fields had got into his hair, which was the colour of a fox's back and never stayed where he put it. He wore the plain tweed and the muted waistcoat of his post in the Duke's private office. The corner of a notebook showed at his waistcoat pocket, as it always did; Alexander had never once seen him put it down anywhere.

"Seven paces," Niall said. "Elbow first."

Alexander took the first knife by the hilt and went to the chalk line. Seven paces from the old chestnut, which Niall had paced out himself in the first spring and could have told anyone the exact distance of in feet and inches if anyone had been fool enough to ask. The painted circle on the butt had been renewed so often that its rings had thickened like the rings of the tree. In the middle of it sat the dark knot he had been aiming at since he was sixteen.

He threw. The knife turned once and went in a hand's breadth low.

"Again."

He threw again, and again, and the yard settled into the sound it had made for six years: the thud, the walk, the pull, the walk back. Here he did not have to be anyone's heir. Here he could be bad at a thing and then less bad at it, and nobody stood in a line behind him.

On the fourth knife Niall said, "Your wrist, Alex," and came up beside him.

He took Alexander's wrist in his left hand, the one with the pale seam of an old scar across the palm, and set it straight. His thumb went to the heel of Alexander's hand, found the raw place where the splinter had come out that morning, and moved without a pause to the other side of the grip, where it would not press. He did not look at the mark. He did not say anything about it. He held the wrist a moment, set, and took his hand away a little before he needed to, as he always did. In the first year he had corrected Alexander's elbow with the flat of another knife and never once with his hand. Alexander could not have said when that had changed.

"Now," Niall said.

The knife went into the second ring, high and to the left, and stayed.

"Better," Niall said, which was the most he ever said.

He took his own turn at the line, the knife held loose beside his head, and then he did the thing Alexander had spent six years learning to read. He paused. It was the smallest thing, a breath held a beat too long before the release, and it meant that Niall was not looking at the target at all. He was looking past it, over the yard wall and the water-meadow, at the tree line on the far side. His eyes, a pale and ordinary blue when he was being dry at Alexander's expense, had gone entirely still. As Alexander watched, the rooks went up out of those trees in a black, complaining shower, and wheeled, and settled again.

Niall threw without looking at the chestnut. The knife went into the dark knot at the centre of the circle as if it had been sent for.

"If you mean to look at the trees all afternoon," Alexander said, "you might at least throw at them."

"Four hundred and ten yards."

"I didn't ask how far."

"You were going to."

"I was going to ask whether the forest had done something to offend you. It hasn't moved in living memory. I'm told it's a point of family pride."

Niall went to pull his knife. He did not answer, and he did not look back at the trees, which was how Alexander knew he was still looking at them. The rooks went up a second time while he was at the target, all at once, as though something had walked underneath them, and came down more slowly than before.

Alexander could have asked. He weighed the knife in his hand and found that he would rather needle a man for an hour than ask him one plain question and be told it was nothing.

"Sir," Niall said, and stepped back from the line.

It took Alexander a moment to understand. Then he heard the gate. Catherine came through it from the kitchen garden in the blue silk, its hem still muddied from the morning, with something white in each hand and the wind pulling her hair further down on one side.

"Lady Catherine," Niall said.

She had heard it, the change from one word to the other. Alexander saw her hear it, in the small check of her step, the way he had once seen her hear a wrong note in a piece she was playing and go on as though she had not.

"Don't stop on my account, Alex," she said. "I've come to give you each something, and then I'll go away and leave you to throw things at that poor tree." She held them out, one to each of them: two handkerchiefs of white lawn, and in the corner of each, in blue thread, a swallow with its tail spread. "For luck," she said, "since neither of you will ever go anywhere to need it."

"Thank you," Alexander said. "I think."

Niall looked at the swallow for a moment longer than he needed to. Then he folded the handkerchief in four, took the notebook from his waistcoat, and put it between two pages, the way he kept anything he meant to keep, and put the notebook back where it lived.

"Thank you, my lady," he said.

Alexander put his own into his pocket with the cravat. He was annoyed, without being able to say at what, and pleased, and he did not care to look closely at either.

Catherine was not looking at the handkerchiefs. She was looking at him, and then, briefly, at Niall, and then at him again, with an expression he had seen on her face before and had never been able to read. She did not say anything. She only smiled, a small private smile that was not meant for either of them, and tucked a lock of hair back that the wind took straight out again.

"Don't let him throw at Mr. Hodge," she said to Niall, "however much he deserves it," and went back the way she had come, and the gate swung shut behind her.

They threw until the hour was gone. Niall did not call him Alex again, and Alexander did not notice that he was waiting for it until he had stopped. The wind freshened. When the last knife was out of the chestnut, Alexander laid it in the box beside the others, pointing the way Niall had always pointed them.

"Tomorrow?" he said.

Niall looked at him, and then, past him, once more at the trees.

"Tomorrow, then."

He shut the lid on the five knives. Behind him, out beyond the water-meadow, the clouds had begun to come up out of the west.

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The cloud had come over by five and stayed, low and the colour of pewter, and when the sun went down behind it there was no afterglow at all. One moment it was late afternoon. The next the footmen were going along the front of the house with tapers, and the lanterns on the carriage sweep were coming up one after another, small and yellow against the dark.

Alexander had meant to be dressed by now. He was on the front steps instead in his riding coat, which the stable boy had brushed and sent back up to him, because the first of the dinner guests were due and his mother had wanted the family at the door. His father stood on the top step in evening black, square and patient. His mother stood beside him. Catherine had come

down last, in a gown of dark green that was very nearly what a duke's daughter ought to wear to dinner, and had at once sat down on the balustrade, which was not.

"The Reverend Mr. Ashby," she said, "will be first. He always is. He likes to have the fire to himself before anyone else gets to it."

"Get off the balustrade," their mother said, without looking round.

Catherine got off it.

They heard the carriage before they saw it, and it was not the Reverend Mr. Ashby's. His came up the hill road with a great deal of noise, a loose wheel-band and a cob that blew like a bellows on the last rise. This came up quietly. There was the grind of wheels on gravel, steady and unhurried, and nothing else, no blowing, no jingle of harness. Then it came into the light of the first lantern: a closed carriage, black, drawn by a pair of black horses that came to a stand at the foot of the steps as neatly as if they had been set down there.

Above them, in the chestnuts, the rooks went up.

They went all at once, every bird in the rookery, with a noise like a sheet being torn, and for a moment the dark over the drive was full of them. Then they were gone, over the roof of the eastern range and away, and they did not come back. The trees they had left were absolutely silent.

Somebody on the steps laughed, uncertainly. It was Catherine. "Well," she said. "That was rude of them."

Alexander looked at the carriage. There was something wrong with it, and it took him a moment to see what. It had no crest. The panel on the door, where any gentleman's carriage carried his arms, was plain black lacquer, as blank as a closed eye. And there were no windows. Where the glass should have been there were panels, close-fitted, and the whole thing stood under the lantern as shut as a box.

He told himself it was a foreign fashion. He told himself a great many things in the next few minutes, and all of them were reasonable.

The horses did not move. The cart horses in the stable yard were stamping and calling to one another, unsettled by the rooks, but this pair stood in their traces with their heads level and

their ears still, and did not so much as shake a bit. They were very fine. He supposed that very fine horses were trained to it.

On the box sat the coachman. He was a young man, thin and colourless, with his hat pulled level and his hands quiet on the reins, and he did not look at the house or the lanterns or the family on the steps. He did not look at anything. His eyes rested on the air between his horses' ears and held nothing of their own. He did not get down to open the door.

The door opened anyway.

The man who stepped down from it did so without haste, as if he had all the evening and had decided to spend a part of it on this. He was tall, and pale, and very finely made, with dark hair worn a little longer than was the fashion, and a black coat that was correct in every particular and might have been cut ten years ago by the best tailor in Vienna. He looked to be somewhere in his late thirties. He stood at the foot of the steps and looked up at them, and smiled, and the smile was a good one. It was exactly the smile a gentleman gave on arriving at a house where he was not expected, warm and apologetic and sure of being forgiven. Alexander had the strange impression that he had seen it before, on someone else.

"Your Grace." The voice was low and unhurried, with an accent too faint to place. "Forgive me. I am early."

"For what, sir?" his father said.

"For everything, I find. I have never learned to be otherwise." He came up the steps. "Hessian. I hold a title from the Emperor that I am not sure your country recognises, so you need not use it. I have come to you about land."

There was a small cold breath of air as he reached the top step, as though a door had been opened somewhere behind him onto a colder room. The nearest lantern flame leaned away from it, and righted itself. Alexander felt it on the backs of his hands. The evening had turned, he thought. September evenings did.

His father did not give the stranger his hand. He did not refuse it either. He simply stood, as he stood at the judging table, and let the silence do what it would, and after a moment Hessian took a letter from inside his coat and offered that instead. It was heavy paper, folded square and sealed in black wax.

"A matter of land," Hessian said. "Your Mr. Hollis will find it tedious. I find that land is never tedious. It is only waiting to be wanted."

Edward took the letter. He turned it over once in his scarred hand and looked at the seal, which carried no device that Alexander could make out from where he stood, only a smooth black disc. Then he put it into the breast of his coat, unopened.

Alexander had seen his father open letters at the breakfast table, at the judging table, once on horseback in a downpour. He had never seen him put one away unread. He felt it as a small cold drop somewhere under his ribs, and could not have said why.

"My wife," Edward said. "The Duchess."

"Duchess." Hessian bowed over her hand without quite touching it.

His mother inclined her head. That was all; she said nothing. But Alexander, who had known her face all his life, saw it close, the way a book is closed when the reader has finished deciding what she thinks of it. Whatever it was, she had decided it in the time it took him to come up the steps.

"My son," his father said. "Lord Wensum."

"Lord Wensum." The title came out precisely, every letter given its due, the way a man speaks a language he has learned very thoroughly from books. Hessian looked at him for a moment with interest, and Alexander understood that he was being looked at the way he himself looked at a house, from the oldest part outward. Then the stranger's eyes moved on.

They moved past his mother, past the lit doorway and the footman holding it, and they found Catherine at the end of the step, in her dark green, with her hair coming down on one side.

And they stayed there.

It was not rudeness. Rudeness would have been easier to bear. Hessian's face had gone entirely still, and in the stillness it was no longer a face in its late thirties, or any age at all; it was only a face, pale and fine and fixed, the way a portrait's face is fixed. His eyes in the lantern light were not quite brown. He did not seem, for that moment, to be breathing. Alexander told himself that the man was simply a man who had learned to be still, and that the lanterns made everyone look strange, and that he was cold because he had not yet dressed.

"And my daughter," his father said, a beat late. "Lady Catherine."

"Lady Catherine," Hessian said softly, and bowed.

Catherine, who questioned every stranger who came within five miles of the district and had once followed a German tinker halfway to Swaffham to ask him about the Rhine, opened her mouth to ask him something. Their mother's hand came to rest on her arm. It did not grip. It only rested there, gloved, and Catherine closed her mouth again and made her curtsey instead, and the moment went by.

Down on the drive, the Reverend Mr. Ashby's cob came blowing up the last of the hill.

"You'll dine with us, Count," his father said. The words came out of him the way they had come out of every Duke of Norwich at every harvest festival for longer than anyone had kept records, as though he had no more choice about them than about the weather. "It's the festival. No one is turned from the door tonight."

Hessian looked at him. Then he smiled again, the good smile, the borrowed one.

"You are generous, Your Grace," he said. "I accept what I am given."

A footman stepped forward to take the Count's hat. Another came to Alexander's elbow. "Your coat brushed for dinner, my lord?" the man said, and it was the "my lord" that went through Alexander. The household only called him that when there was a stranger in the house, and for the first time in his life he heard it as a warning.

"Yes," he said. "Thank you."

He went in to dress. On the stair he stopped, for no reason, and looked out through the landing window at the chestnuts on the drive. They stood black against the last of the grey, every branch of them empty. Behind him, down in the hall, he heard the stranger laugh at something the Reverend Mr. Ashby had said, a pleasant laugh, exactly as long as it ought to have been.

He was cold all the way up to his room, and it was not until he had shut the door that he noticed he had been listening, the whole way, for the rooks.

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The great hall had been dressed for the harvest since Thursday. Sheaves stood bound in the corners, and swags of wheat and red ribbon ran the length of the gallery rail, and someone, in a spirit Alexander suspected was Catherine's, had set Farmer Hodge's prize marrow in the middle of the high table between two branches of candles, where it lay in state like a bishop. The fire was built high. The long table was full: the Reverend Mr. Ashby and his wife, the Fenwicks and the Hodges and the other senior tenants in their best, the Lowndes from Holt, Thomas Barrow in his formal coat looking as if it pinched him. Wood smoke and beeswax and roast goose. And under the door at the bottom of the hall, where it always came in on a September night, a thin draught that found Alexander's ankles and stayed there.

He had dressed. He had stood in front of his fire for ten minutes before he went down, and he was still cold.

The Count had been put at his mother's right hand, as a foreign nobleman must be, and Catherine directly across from him, as no one had intended. Miss Gray sat two places down from the Count. She had walked the two miles from her cottage before the lamps were lit, as she always did, and had spent the hour before dinner upstairs with his mother, as she always did, and she had come down to table in the same grey wool she wore to walk in, with the same plain amulet at her throat. She was tall and spare and very straight, with dark hair and a single streak of white in it, and a face the weather had worked on for a great many years. Alexander had known her all his life as his mother's odd friend, who smelled of lavender and woodsmoke and old paper, and who had once, when he was six, looked into a basin of water for him and told him gravely that he would be tall.

O'Brien moved behind the chairs with the wine. The steward was sixty, silver-haired, and pressed as sharp as a new card, and he had spent forty years at this table being noticed by no one, which was his art. His face gave away nothing at all. It never did.

Alexander had wanted one thing from the evening, which was for it to pass. He wanted the goose carved and the toasts made and the Reverend Mr. Ashby's speech about the harvest got through in under a quarter of an hour, and he wanted his sister not to begin on the Rhine. Catherine at a dinner table with a stranger who had travelled was a horse with the bit between its teeth.

She began on the Rhine before the soup was cleared.

It was not, in fairness, her fault. The Count drew her out. He did it very well, with small questions laid down one at a time like a man setting out cards, and he listened to her answers in a way Alexander had never seen anyone listen to Catherine. He did not listen the way their father did, with patience, or the way Alexander did, with half his mind elsewhere. He listened the way a locksmith listens to the tumblers of a lock, with his head a little on one side, as though each word she said was falling into place somewhere inside her and he could hear it land.

"My mother has friends abroad," Catherine was saying, "who write to her. One in Vienna and one in Pest and an old gentleman in Ragusa who writes entirely about his figs. They send the most wonderful letters. About the opera, and the ice on the river, and a procession with lanterns that went all the way down to the water." Her colour was high. She had drunk half a glass of claret and eaten nothing, and she leaned across the cloth toward him with her hands folded under her chin. "Have you been on the Danube, Count?"

"I was born above it," Hessian said.

He told her about it. He told it well. He described a gorge in the far east of the Empire where the river went through the mountains between cliffs so high and so close that the sun reached the water for an hour a day; the Iron Gates, he said, the boatmen called it, and they crossed themselves going in. He described whirlpools that could turn a barge end for end, and a fortress on a crag above them where the wind never stopped, and the villages of the Carpathians where the women painted their doors blue against the evil eye. He had a low, unhurried voice that made the hall seem to lean in toward it, and the Hodges at the far end had stopped eating to listen. It was a fine account. Alexander noticed, without quite meaning to, that the Count had eaten nothing while he gave it. His goose lay carved on his plate and he had moved it from one side to the other with his fork, once, as a man might move a piece on a board. His wine stood untouched at his right hand. As he finished speaking he put out two fingers and turned the glass a quarter turn on the cloth, and left it.

Catherine had not taken her eyes from him.

"Can you imagine?" she said. She said it not to him but to the table, to all of them, as if it had been forced out of her. "Actually seeing any of it. Not reading it in someone's letters home. Seeing it?"

Hessian did not answer. He looked at her, and his face did the thing it had done on the steps: it went still, and in the stillness it stopped being any particular age. But it was not the same stillness. On the steps it had been the stillness of a man startled. This was the stillness of a man who has been listening for a long time at a door and has at last heard, from the other side, the sound he was waiting for.

Then he smiled at her, the good smile, and the moment passed, and the Reverend Mr. Ashby began to say something about the Euphrates in the Book of Revelation.

"He powders," Catherine said, low, to Alexander, under cover of it. She had leaned toward him behind her glass. "Did you see? At his collar. There's a line where it stops." She looked delighted. "I think it's rather sweet. A great foreign count, and he's vain as a curate."

Alexander looked. In the candlelight there was, perhaps, a faint pale line along the edge of the Count's collar where the skin above it was a shade whiter than the skin below. He would not have seen it if she had not told him. He decided she was right, and that it was sweet, and that he did not like it.

"Don't stare," he said. "You'll embarrass him."

"I never embarrass anyone. I'm a delight." But she sat back.

It was then that Alexander noticed Miss Gray.

She had not spoken through the whole of the Count's account. She sat very upright with her hands in her lap, and now one of them had come up to the amulet at her throat and closed on it. Her left eye, the odd one, which had always caught the light strangely, had clouded over like a pane of glass when someone breathes on it, and as he watched, a thin silver came up into the cloud from underneath, the way a tarnished spoon shows its silver when it is rubbed. She was looking at the Count. Then she looked down the table at Alexander's mother, a long look, and she opened her mouth.

She closed it again. Her hand stayed on the amulet. She said nothing at all.

Alexander had seen her eye do that before, at christenings and funerals, once when a storm came in off the sea. It was Miss Gray's oddness. Everyone in the district knew about it and no one remarked on it, as no one remarked on the vicar's limp. He looked away from her and

back to his plate, and when he looked up again the silver had gone out of the eye and it was only grey.

"You said this evening that you'd come about land, Count." His father's voice came down the table, easy and pleasant, the voice he used at tenants' dinners to bring a conversation round from wherever it had wandered to wherever he wanted it. He had thirty years of practice at it and it showed. "You'll find Norfolk poor hunting for that. We drain what we have and keep it. But if it's remote ground that interests you, there's land in the north of Scotland that nobody has wanted in a hundred years."

Hessian turned his head. "In the north?"

"Wester Ross. Near Loch Maree. Rock and heather and a good deal of weather." His father reached for his own glass. "My grandfather used to say it was the only property he owned that had never once given him trouble, because there was nothing on it to give any."

"How very restful," Hessian said. "I collect land that no one else particularly wants. It is a foreign eccentricity."

Alexander looked at his father. He could not think why he had brought it up. The northern tract was a line in the ledgers even more remote than Harrow's Fen, a figure for rates and nothing else, and he had never in his life heard his father offer anything to anyone across a dinner table. His mother's face was perfectly calm. She was cutting a piece of goose very small.

The talk went on. The toasts were made. The Reverend Mr. Ashby's speech ran to twenty minutes. Before the ladies rose, the Count excused himself, with his grave correct courtesy, to take a little air, and O'Brien drew back his chair, and he went out by the door at the bottom of the hall where the draught came in.

O'Brien came along the table behind him to clear his place. He lifted the Count's plate with the goose still on it, and then the Count's glass, and Alexander, watching for no reason he could name, saw that the wine in it stood exactly as high as it had when O'Brien poured it. Not a sip. Not the smallest mark on the rim.

O'Brien's face gave away nothing. He carried the full glass out with the plate as though it were empty, and Alexander, who did not like the Count, told himself that a foreigner might very well not care for claret.

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By half past eleven the house had gone quiet the way it always did after a festival dinner, not all at once but a room at a time, as if someone were walking through it putting out the noise like candles. Alexander had gone up, and undressed, and lain for half an hour under two blankets without getting warm, and then he had dressed again and gone down by the back stair in his shirt and an old coat to stand somewhere that was honestly cold, which seemed better.

The kitchen garden was dark. There was no moon. The cloud that had come up in the afternoon had settled over the whole county like a lid, and the only light came from the house behind him, a few late windows: the kitchen, where someone was still scouring pans, and high up at the end of the east range, in the tall windows of the long gallery, a single candle. Catherine, he thought. She never could sleep after company. The garden smelled of turned earth and the last of the fennel, sharp and sweet where he brushed it, and beyond the low wall at the bottom the dark went on without any shape at all.

Niall was standing at the end of the bean rows.

He had his coat on and his hands in his pockets, and he was not doing anything, not smoking, not walking. He was simply standing in the middle of the cabbages at midnight, facing the wall, the way he had stood at the chalk line that afternoon facing the trees. He did not turn round. He had heard Alexander come down the steps; Alexander had never once in six years got near him without being heard.

"You're on watch," Alexander said.

"I'm taking the air."

"In the dark. Among the cabbages."

"They're quiet company." Niall did not look away from the wall. "Unlike some."

Alexander came and stood beside him. It was a little warmer there, or he imagined it was. Up in the chestnuts along the drive there was not a sound. He had not noticed until now that the rooks had never come back.

"You saw something this afternoon," he said. "In the trees."

"I saw rooks."

"You saw what put them up."

Niall did not answer that. Alexander was trying to decide whether to push it, and was finding again, as he had at the chalk line, that he would rather do almost anything than ask a plain question and be given a plain nothing in return, when something moved on top of the garden wall.

He did not see it so much as see the dark change shape. A piece of the night at the top of the wall, forty yards off, was blacker than the rest, and then it was larger, and then there was a sound like a heavy cloak thrown open, once, and a gust of air came across the cabbages and lifted the hair off his forehead.

Niall was already moving.

He did not run, exactly. He went down the path between the bean rows at a long, quick, silent stride, and when he came to the wall he went over it without breaking that stride, one hand on the coping, and was gone.

"Stay there, Alex," came back over the wall, low.

Alexander did not stay there. He went down the path after him as fast as he could in the dark, which was not fast, and turned his ankle on the edge of a bed, and caught himself, and reached the wall. It was chest-high. He put his hands on it and looked over into the paddock beyond, and there was nothing. No Niall. No shape. Only the dark, and the wet smell of grass, and very far off the sound of the last of the festival, a single drunk voice singing on the hill road, going home.

He listened. He heard nothing move in the paddock. He heard nothing in the air. He stood with his hands on the cold coping and was aware, all at once and absurdly, that he was afraid, and that he had no idea of what.

It was perhaps five minutes before Niall came back. Alexander heard him this time, his boots in the wet grass, and then he came over the wall the way he had gone, lightly, and dropped down beside him breathing hard. He had something in his hand.

"What was it?"

Niall held it up into what little light came from the kitchen window. It was a feather. It was a wing feather, a flight feather, dark and barred with a paler brown, the vane stiff and whole and the quill as thick as a pen. And it was long. It was longer than Alexander's forearm from elbow to fingertip. He knew every large bird in the county. He had seen herons stand in the Fen and swans come down on the river, and when he was a small boy his father had taken him out on the brecks near Thetford to see the last of the great bustards, a pair of them, before they were gone from Norfolk for good. None of them had ever carried a feather like that.

"What is it?" he said again.

Niall looked at the feather for a moment. His face in the window light was perfectly calm, and perfectly closed, in a way Alexander had seen once already that day. Then he opened his coat and put the feather inside it.

"Nothing you need to carry tonight," he said.

It was what his father had done on the steps with the letter. It was the same small movement, the coat opened, the thing put away against the chest, the coat closed over it, and Alexander, standing with his hands still on the wall, understood that he had now been shut out of two things in one day by the two men he would most have liked to be let in by.

"Go up," Niall said, more gently. "You'll take cold."

"I've been cold since six o'clock."

Niall looked at him then, really looked, for the first time since he had come down the steps. Whatever he was going to say, he did not say it. "Go up anyway," he said.

Alexander went. At the top of the kitchen steps he turned. Niall had not moved from the wall. He was standing where Alexander had left him, with his back to the house and his hand flat against his coat over the place where the feather was, looking out into a dark that had nothing in it. And high above the garden, in the tall windows at the end of the long gallery, the single candle was still burning.

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Catherine had come to the long gallery because it was the one room in the house where nobody ever was.

She had brought one candle and set it on the sill of the last window, and she sat on the window seat beside it with her feet tucked up under the green silk and her back against the cold glass, and listened to the house finish being loud. It was like the last bars of a piece played by too many people: one by one they lifted their bows, and the sound got thinner, and in the end there was only the clock on the landing and her own heart going, rather fast still, from the claret, or the evening, or the Iron Gates.

The Iron Gates. She had them in her head and could not get them out. Cliffs so close the sun only touched the water for an hour. Whirlpools that turned a barge end for end. Doors painted blue. She had the place on a map already, she was nearly sure, on the page of her atlas where the Danube came down out of Hungary and went through the mountains in a thin blue thread, and she had touched that thread a hundred times without knowing there was anything there to touch. Now there was. Now there was a fortress on a crag and a wind that never stopped. She wanted it so badly that it felt like hunger, and she sat with it in the candlelight, and was ashamed, and did not let it go.

Down the length of the gallery her great-great-grandmothers looked at her out of their frames. Every one of them had been painted indoors. She had noticed it when she was twelve and never been able to stop noticing it: a Sterling woman in a blue room, a Sterling woman in a red room, a Sterling woman with a spaniel in a room with a window behind her, and through the window, very small, the park, painted in as an afterthought. Great-grandmamma Harriet had never once been out of Norfolk and had been proud of it all her life. She hung by the door, in grey, holding a prayer book, looking pleased.

Down in the garden somebody called out, a man's voice, low and short. Alexander's, she thought, and then not, and then she did not think about it any further, because when she turned her head from the window the Count was standing six feet away from her in the candlelight.

She had not heard him come. That was odd, a little, on those boards; they had sung under every footstep since she was a child, and Alexander could not cross the gallery without it announcing him like a herald. But the Count was a foreigner, and a light man for his height, and

perhaps the boards were kinder to people they did not know. She found that she was not frightened. She found that she was rather glad.

"Forgive me," he said. "I have startled you."

"No. I didn't hear you, that's all. Everyone else in this house sounds like a dropped tray." She did not get up, though she knew she ought to, and he did not seem to expect it. "Are you lost, Count? People get lost. It's a very badly designed house. It was built by four different Sterlings who all disliked each other."

"I was looking at your ancestors." He turned his head to the long row of them, unhurried. "They are very handsome. And very still."

"They're always indoors," Catherine said. "Have you noticed? Every one of them. I used to think it was the painter's fault."

"And now?"

She looked at Great-grandmamma Harriet with her prayer book. "Now I think it's the family's."

He did not laugh, as most people would have, to show her that she was being amusing. He came a little nearer, into the light, and stood at the end of the window seat with his hands behind his back, and looked at her. His face in the candlelight was pale and grave and kind, and he was waiting for her to say more, and it came to her that nobody in her life had ever simply waited for her to say more. People waited for her to finish.

"What do you want of your life, Lady Catherine?" he asked.

It was such a strange thing for a man to ask, and he asked it so quietly, as if it were the only question in the world worth asking, that she answered it. Not with what she wanted. She had never said what she wanted to anyone, not even to Alex, and she did not say it now. She said what she was going to have.

"Oh, it's all arranged," she said. "It's very simple. I shall be proper. I am already quite proper, you know, when anyone's looking. In a year or two Papa will find someone suitable, and he will be a perfectly good man with a perfectly good house in a perfectly good county, probably this one, and I shall go and live in his rooms instead of my father's. I shall have very nice rooms.

I shall choose the curtains. And one day someone will paint me in one of them, with a spaniel, and they'll hang me down there next to Great-grandmamma, and some girl will sit here on this seat in a hundred years and wonder why I never went outside." She heard her own voice go thin at the end, and laughed to cover it. "That's all. It's a very good life. Everyone says so."

The Count was quiet for a moment. The candle flame stood perfectly straight between them; there was no draught in the gallery at all.

"That sounds less like a life than a waiting room."

Catherine went still.

It was the thing. It was the exact thing, the thought she had carried about with her since she was twelve years old and had never once let out of her mouth, not to her mother and not to Alex and not to Bess, not even to the page of the atlas where she kept everything else. A waiting room. A room full of very nice chairs where you sat with your hands in your lap until someone came to the door and called your name, and then you went into another room exactly like it. She had never found the words for it, and this man had walked out of the dark and handed them to her as if she had dropped them.

Something loosened in her chest, warm and frightening, like the first notes of a piece she had wanted all her life to be able to play.

"Yes," she said. "That's exactly what it is."

He inclined his head, as though she had confirmed something he had already known.

"I am to call on your father on Tuesday," he said, "about a little wet meadow I saw from the road. I think he will not wish to sell it to me."

"Harrow's Fen?" She laughed, and this time it was real. "No. He won't. He'd sooner sell me."

The Count looked at her. He did not laugh with her. He only looked, with that grave, kind, waiting face, until her laugh ran out of its own accord and left the gallery very quiet.

"Goodnight, Lady Catherine," he said, and bowed, and went back down the long gallery between her painted grandmothers, and she did not hear his steps on the boards at all.

She sat on in the window seat after he had gone, with her arms round her knees. The candle had burned down to a stub. Outside the tall windows the night was perfectly black, without a star, and somewhere below in the garden a man was standing by the wall, but she did not look down to see who. She was thinking of a gorge where the sun reached the water for one hour in the day. She was thinking that someone had finally said it out loud.

She wanted very much to hear him say it again.

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